mores of the Nairs caused something of a sensation.[6] One of his readers was a young English aristocrat named James Lawrence, who got it into his head that here on India's Malabar coast there was to be found a paradise of free love. 'The Nairs are the Nobility of the Malabar Coast, and affirm that they are the oldest in the world,' Lawrence wrote in the introduction to his novel published in 1811 in France, Germany and England under the title *The Empire of the Nairs, or, the Rights of Woman: an Utopian Romance in twelve books*. 'It is the privilege of the Nair lady to chose and change her lover … The mother only has the charge of the children; and even the *Samorin* [Zamorin] and other princes have no other heirs than the children of their sisters. The name of the father is unknown to a Nair child; he speaks of the lovers of his mother, and of his uncles, but never of his father. Such are the Nairs.'

Lawrence's romance was intended to demonstrate the superiority of what he referred to as 'the Nair system of gallantry' over conventional marriage, 'in insuring an indubitable birth, and being favourable to population, to the rights of women, and to the active genius of men'. These ideals appealed to many young romantics in Europe, among them the poet Percy Shelley, who wrote to Lawrence declaring himself a convert to Lawrence's ideas and describing marriage as 'licensed prostitution'. But Lawrence's utopian vision of free love was, of course, a Western fantasy, for the reality was much darker. If a Nair woman was caught bestowing her favours on any person of lower caste than herself she was instantly declared an outcaste. Even more severe penalties were applied to the men, as Buchanan noted: 'A Nair man who is detected in fornication with a Shanar woman is put to death, and the woman is sold to the Moplays [Muslims]. If he have connection with a slave girl, both are put to death.'